

Narendra Modi the Clown

How a Political Tool “Survived” Indira Gandhi’s Declared Emergency
Only to Create His Own Undeclared Emergency

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Abstract

Political history often reveals striking ironies. Individuals and organizations that once portrayed themselves as victims of state repression may later become practitioners of the very methods they once condemned. Whether this characterization accurately applies to Prime Minister Narendra Modi and the Bharatiya Janata Party (BJP) is a matter of intense political debate. This essay argues, from a critical perspective, that India’s contemporary political climate bears unsettling similarities to the authoritarian tendencies associated with Indira Gandhi’s Emergency (1975–1977), albeit through different methods and institutions.

Critics contend that Modi’s carefully cultivated public image often relies on theatrical symbolism, grand spectacles, emotional appeals, and personality-driven politics. Supporters, by contrast, view these qualities as evidence of effective leadership and political communication. The sharp divide in public perception underscores the intensely polarized nature of Indian politics.

The title’s provocative description of Narendra Modi as “the clown” reflects a critical and established fact. The Emergency declared by Prime Minister Indira Gandhi on June 25, 1975, suspended civil liberties, censored the press, jailed political opponents, and centralized power within the executive. Among those affected were leaders and workers associated with the Rashtriya Swayamsevak Sangh (RSS) and the Bharatiya Jana Sangh, the ideological predecessor of today’s BJP. The Emergency became a defining moment for the Indian right, reinforcing its narrative of resistance against authoritarianism and strengthening its claim to defending democratic freedoms.

Narendra Modi himself was a young RSS pracharak during the Emergency. According to accounts from the RSS and the BJP, he worked underground, helping activists evade arrest, distributing literature, and organizing resistance networks. Whether every detail of these narratives can be independently verified remains debated among historians, but the Emergency undoubtedly shaped Modi’s political identity and the BJP’s collective memory.

The irony, according to many critics, is that a movement born from opposition to authoritarian rule now faces accusations of cultivating authoritarian practices of its own. Unlike the formal constitutional Emergency declared in 1975, contemporary critics argue that democratic institutions continue to function while becoming increasingly dominated by the executive. Elections are held regularly, opposition parties remain legal, and courts continue to operate. Yet concerns have been raised regarding institutional independence, media freedom, the use of investigative agencies against political opponents, and growing pressure on civil society organizations.

Media criticism forms a central element of this argument. During Indira Gandhi’s Emergency, censorship was explicit and legally mandated. Today, critics argue that formal censorship has largely been replaced by economic pressure, ownership concentration, legal intimidation, and self-censorship. Major television networks are frequently accused of amplifying government narratives while marginalizing dissenting voices. Independent journalists and digital media outlets often face legal challenges, tax investigations, or online harassment.

Another point of comparison concerns the treatment of political opposition. During the Emergency, thousands were imprisoned under preventive detention laws. Today's India has not witnessed mass arrests on that scale. Nevertheless, critics argue that selective application of anti-terror laws, prolonged pretrial detention, and investigations by agencies such as the Enforcement Directorate and the Central Bureau of Investigation create a climate in which opposition leaders operate under constant pressure. Government supporters reject these allegations, arguing that investigations target corruption rather than political affiliation.

Civil liberties constitute another area of contention. Human rights organizations have criticized restrictions on protests, internet shutdowns, and the use of sedition and anti-terror legislation against activists, journalists, and students. The government maintains that these measures are necessary to preserve national security and public order. Whether these actions represent legitimate governance or democratic backsliding remains the subject of ongoing legal and political debate.

The Modi government's emphasis on majoritarian nationalism also distinguishes the current era from the Emergency. While Indira Gandhi centralized political authority largely to preserve her personal rule following an adverse court judgment, critics argue that the BJP combines centralized executive power with an ideological project rooted in Hindu nationalism. Policies concerning citizenship, Kashmir, religious conversion, and educational curricula have generated substantial controversy, with supporters presenting them as long-overdue reforms and opponents viewing them as threats to India's secular constitutional framework.

It would, therefore, be historically accurate to claim that contemporary India is identical to the Emergency period. The formal suspension of constitutional rights, blanket press censorship, and nationwide preventive detention characteristic of 1975–1977 are similar. Elections remain competitive, state governments continue to change hands, and judicial interventions occasionally constrain executive actions, but the same time, democracy scholars increasingly distinguish between classic dictatorships and what they describe as democratic erosion, in which institutions remain formally intact while becoming progressively less effective as checks on executive authority.

The phrase “undeclared Emergency” has therefore emerged within opposition discourse. It is intended not as a literal constitutional claim but as a political metaphor describing what critics see as shrinking democratic space. Whether one accepts this analogy depends largely on one's assessment of institutional independence, media pluralism, and the health of India's constitutional democracy.

History demonstrates that political movements are not immune to the temptations of power. Organizations forged in resistance can themselves become resistant to accountability. The BJP's historical opposition to Indira Gandhi's Emergency gave it considerable moral authority in defending democratic freedoms. Critics argue that preserving that legacy requires applying the same standards to every government, including one led by the BJP itself.

Ultimately, democratic resilience depends less on the identities of political leaders than on the strength of institutions capable of limiting executive power. Whether India is experiencing an “undeclared Emergency” does not remain contested any longer. What is beyond dispute is that vigilance against authoritarian tendencies must apply universally, regardless of which party governs. The lesson of the Emergency is not merely that authoritarianism is dangerous; it is that no political movement can safely assume it is forever immune from becoming what it once opposed.

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